

LEGACYWORKS

A FREE GUIDE

10 Questions to Ask *Before* *It's Too Late*

The conversations families most wish they'd had — and exactly how to begin them, while there's still time.

Every life remembered.

CAPTURE · PRESERVE · REMEMBER

The questions we *mean* to ask.

Ask anyone who has lost a parent what they wish they had done differently, and you tend to hear the same quiet answer: *I wish I had asked more.*

Not about the big milestones — the weddings, the moves, the jobs. Those live in photo albums and everyone remembers them. It's the smaller things that slip away. What they were afraid of. What they were proud of. The story behind the story. The sound of their laugh as they told it.

These are the things no document preserves. They live in one place only — in the person — and they don't survive on their own. The good news is that they're easy to capture, if you know what to ask and how to ask it. That's what this guide is for.

You don't need special equipment or training. You just need the right questions, a little time, and the willingness to listen.

On the pages that follow are ten questions families tell us unlocked the stories they treasure most — each with a note on **why it works** and gentle follow-ups to go deeper. After the questions, you'll find a short set of tips for capturing the answers well, however you choose to record them.

A gentle suggestion: don't try to ask all ten at once. The best conversations breathe. Pick two or three, sit down without a clock, and let the rest come another day. The stories that matter most rarely arrive on the first try — they surface when someone feels truly listened to.

The Ten Questions

Part one — beginnings, roots, and the people who shaped them

1

What's your earliest memory?

Why it works: It's an easy, disarming place to start — no pressure, no big themes — and it almost always opens a door to a time and place the family never knew.

Try next: How old were you? Who else was there? What did that place look like, sound like, smell like?

2

Who did you look up to when you were young — and why?

Why it works: It reveals the people who shaped them, often relatives now gone, and the values they absorbed without ever naming them.

Try next: What did they teach you? Is there something of them you still carry today?

3

What was your family like when you were growing up?

Why it works: It captures a whole world that no longer exists — the house, the routines, the personalities — and roots the family tree in real, living detail.

Try next: Where did you live? What did a typical evening look like? What did your parents do?

4

Is there a decision that changed the course of your life?

Why it works: It moves gently from facts to meaning, inviting them to reflect on turning points — and often surfaces a story the family has never heard.

Try next: What might have happened otherwise? Do you have any regrets, or none at all?

5

When did you feel most proud of yourself?

Why it works: It gives them permission to celebrate a moment they may have never spoken about — and those moments are often not the ones the family would guess.

Try next: Who did you want to tell first? Did the people around you know how much it meant?

The Ten Questions

Part two — hardship, love, wisdom, and what lasts

6

What's the hardest thing you've lived through?

Why it works: Asked with care, this is often where the most meaningful stories live. It honors their resilience and shows the family a strength they may never have fully understood.

Try next: How did you get through it? What or who helped? What did it teach you?

7

How did you know you'd found the right person?

Why it works: Whether about a spouse, a friend, or a great love, it brings warmth and often laughter — and preserves a love story in their own words.

Try next: What do you remember about the beginning? What has kept it strong?

8

What do you know now that you wish you'd known at 25?

Why it works: It turns a lifetime of experience into wisdom the next generation can actually hold — the closest thing to advice they'll be able to replay for years.

Try next: What would you tell your younger self? What turned out not to matter at all?

9

What are you most grateful for?

Why it works: It ends on warmth and meaning, and often draws out a tender, summarizing reflection on the life they've lived.

Try next: Who shaped who you became? What are you glad you didn't miss?

10

How do you hope your family will remember you?

Why it works: This is the one families most often forget to ask — and most wish they had. It invites them to speak directly to the generations who'll come after.

Try next: What would you want your grandchildren to know? Is there anything you've never said that you'd want them to hear?

Capturing the answers well

Five simple tips — whatever you're recording with

- 1 Record it, even simply.**
A phone propped against some books is enough. Years from now, no one will notice the production — they'll only care that you captured the voice at all. Video beats audio; audio beats nothing, by a mile.
- 2 Ask, then be quiet.**
The magic happens in the silence after they finish. Resist the urge to fill it. Count to three. Often the most honest, unrehearsed part of the answer comes only after the pause.
- 3 Sit somewhere they feel at ease.**
Their own kitchen table, their favorite chair. Comfort opens people up far more than a perfect setting. Turn off the TV, silence phones, and let it feel like an unhurried conversation — because that's what it is.
- 4 Follow the feeling, not the list.**
If a question sparks something, chase it. These ten are a starting point, not a script. The best stories almost always live one gentle "tell me more about that" beyond the first answer.
- 5 Do it sooner than feels necessary.**
The most common regret is waiting. There is rarely a perfect time, and the chance to capture a voice does not last forever. This week beats next month. Today beats someday.

Whatever you capture, you will never regret having done it. The only version of this you'll regret is the one you didn't make.

WHEN YOU'RE READY TO GO FURTHER

Want it done *beautifully*?

This guide will help you capture something precious on your own. But if you'd like your loved one's story preserved to keep forever — filmed, transcribed, and turned into a finished heirloom — that's what we do at LegacyWorks. There's a path for every family and every budget.

Story Starter From \$100 The complete do-it-yourself kit	Story Keeper \$2,500–\$4,995 Coached & done for you	Story Legacy \$25K–\$100K A cinematic documentary
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Every life remembered.